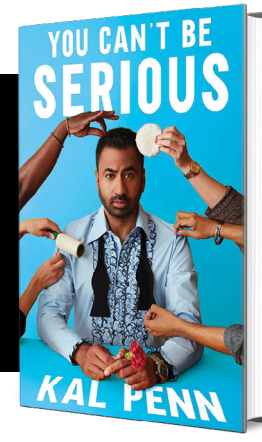
When Kal Penn was in high school, his guidance counsellor, Mrs Cummings, called him to her office to discuss his future. Though still in his teens, Penn had a plan. He wanted to be an actor and filmmaker. Once his career got going, he also wanted to do something civic-minded—development or non-profit work. Mrs Cumming's advice was both a little condescending and cliched: "You can't have your cake and eat it, too." The title of Penn's memoir, *You Can't Be Serious*, as also its witty, disarming content, seem, in many ways, to be Penn's response to his counsellor. "I will say I have no malice towards her."

Speaking to INDIA TODAY over Zoom from his Los Angeles home, Penn, 44, says, "There are tons of kids like me, even today, who have guidance counsellors like that. And I hope that when they read my story, the story of my films—*Harold & Kumar*, *The Namesake*—they see that the way to deal with somebody who is simply discouraging you, is to still try and go after all that you have so badly wanted."

Going after what he wanted, though, was never easy for Penn. His account of his early acting days, for instance, is both a lesson in perseverance and a repudiation of discrimination. "Before auditioning, I would prepare a whole series of backstories for a character, only to walk in and have somebody go, 'Where's your turban?'" At one point, a potential manager even turned him down, saying, "Somebody who looks like you is never going to work in Hollywood." Rather than despair, Penn relied on his pluck. Once he changed his name from Kalpen Modi to Kal Penn, jobs, surely enough, started trickling in.

YOU CAN'T BE SERIOUS
by Kal Penn
SIMON & SCHUSTER
₹699; 384 pages



Penn's several successes during his 25-year acting career have never quite been his alone. Released in 2004, it was *Harold & Kumar Go to White Castle*, a stoner comedy, that made Penn a star, but it also seemed to give a grossly underrepresented South Asian diaspora some much-needed pop culture visibility. Penn's portrayal of Gogol in Mira Nair's *The Namesake* (2006) did endear him to Indian audiences, but it also gave young Indian Americans a character they could finally find themselves in.

According to Penn, technology, and the advent of OTT platforms, in particular, have together helped transform the diversity and representation debate. "I don't think I could have dreamed that I would turn on Netflix and see so many talented brown writers, producers, actors and musicians. Hasan Minhaj is selling out stadiums across the US. Priyanka Chopra was in *The Matrix*. Mindy Kaling is producing three shows. Lilly Singh was the first woman to host a Late Night show. It is all so exciting!"

Penn says his feet have always been in two worlds. Growing up, he heard his grandparents tell him stories about how they each marched with Gandhi. There is a moving scene in the book where his grandfather shows Penn a scar on his leg he got from a beating by colonial policemen.

"In high school, when I read about the American civil rights movement, the idea of non-violent civil disobedience, I realised my grandfather's scar was a symbol of him standing up for our human rights."

The courage which Penn inherited from his grandparents, perhaps, manifested itself most obviously when he decided to take a two-year sabbatical from acting to join the Obama administration. In the chapters that Penn dedicates to campaigning duties and governmental work, one finds inspiration and also, at times, a 'lightness' that seems missing from politics today. "I have been humbled by President Obama several times, but it was very special to have the chance to put together the first ever Diwali at the White House for him. We wanted to put all faiths together on one platform and celebrate light overcoming darkness. The idea was never to simply make a bunch of some Indians happy," Penn says.

Though *You Can't Be Serious* is first "a book about how your life can have more than one story professionally", it does hit some wonderfully resonant notes when it's personal. Penn describes his relationships with his parents and his fiancé Josh with a novel, often humorous, warmth. When asked if he was surprised by the 'coming out' headlines that followed the release of his book, Penn said, "The chapters about Josh and my parents were, strangely, easy to write. Other bits were more blood, sweat and tears. People, of course, will identify with the stories they choose. I was happy to share them all." ■

–Shreevatsa Nevatia